

Q: How do you profile the traveller to make sure you make the right product offering?

A: There is a lot of data available, but we must be very careful with that part... Data privacy is a big issue across the world, and we constantly look to pick up interesting trends. That comes from different sources apart from our own market surveys. Many international consultants come out with comprehensive reports, and we also share a lot of information and data with tourism boards. That helps us to verify a lot of data and eventually make a better and more relevant offering to the traveller.

In general, today people are travelling a lot more but on shorter holidays, especially those [travellers] based in Europe. A lot of that has to do with Covid-19 or the ability to work remotely. That means we have people taking time out in the middle of the week. You can take a day off and carry your skiing equipment. In the middle of that, you can also work remotely. That was never the case in the past. That is a very useful insight for us and with what our own team can do on data analytics, it is possible to build on any of the nuggets.

Q: How critical is India as a market today for Rail Europe?

A: India was always in the Top 5 or Top 6. That has changed sharply and today it is the second largest after the US. That means, after the US, on a sales number basis for Rail Europe, we have the second largest number of people visiting Europe from India.

Our belief is that it is possible to have a growth of 25% out of India from now on. India has become the second-largest market [for us] at a time when many countries are struggling. This is a perfect starting point for India to grow even more. While the US is the largest, it is now followed by India and from thereon, it is South Korea, China and Australia. We were founded in the US 90 years ago and that makes the brand very



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strong there. From India’s point of view, the potential is huge, and we need to build on that.

We sold 5 million tickets last year—of that India was 0.5 million and the US was 1.5 million. Most of the rest came from Europe, the Asia-Pacific region, Australia and the Middle East. I just want to point out here that the Middle East has a small population but becomes very convenient because of very good air connectivity into Europe. It also translates to a huge advantage for